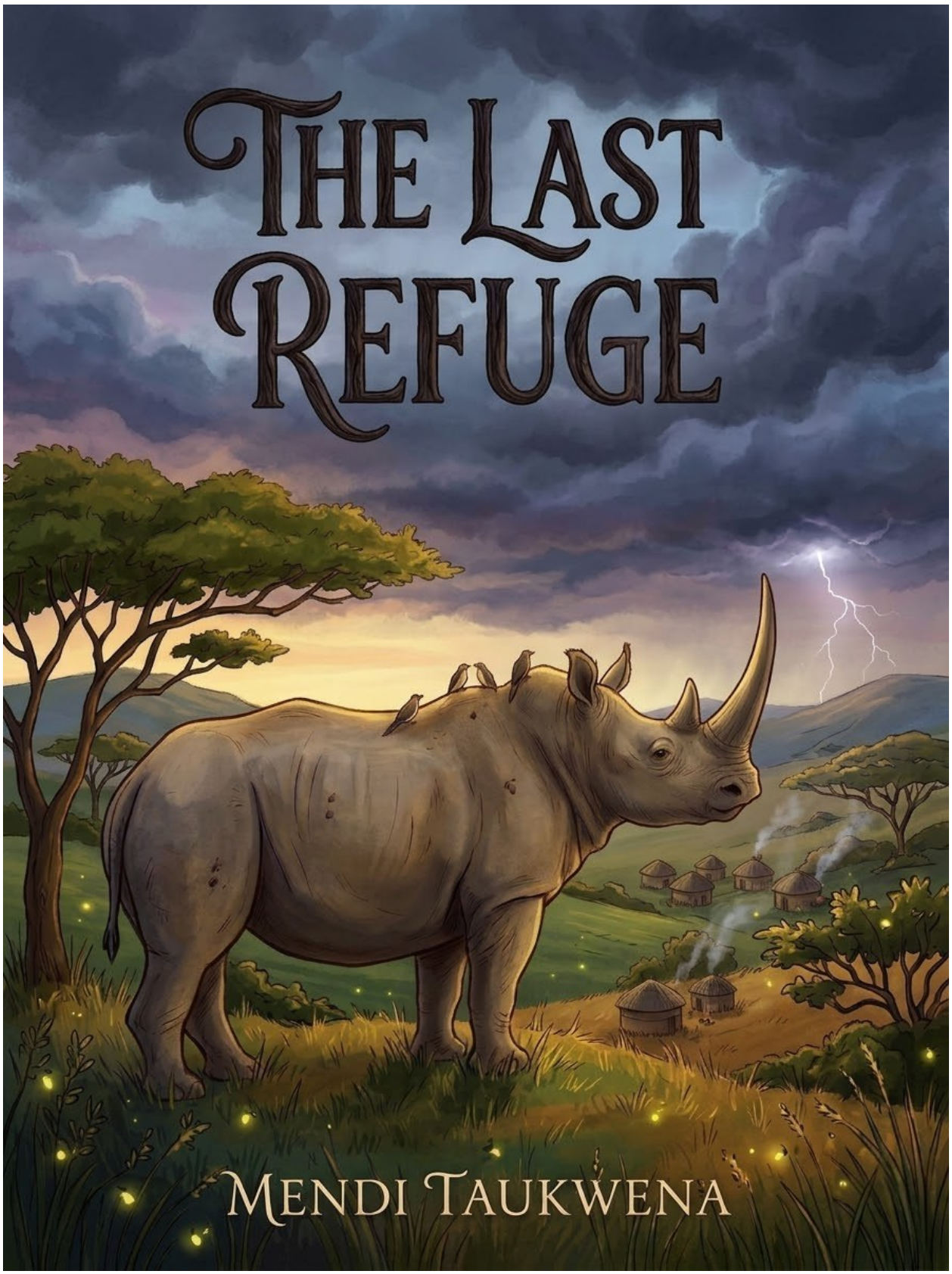
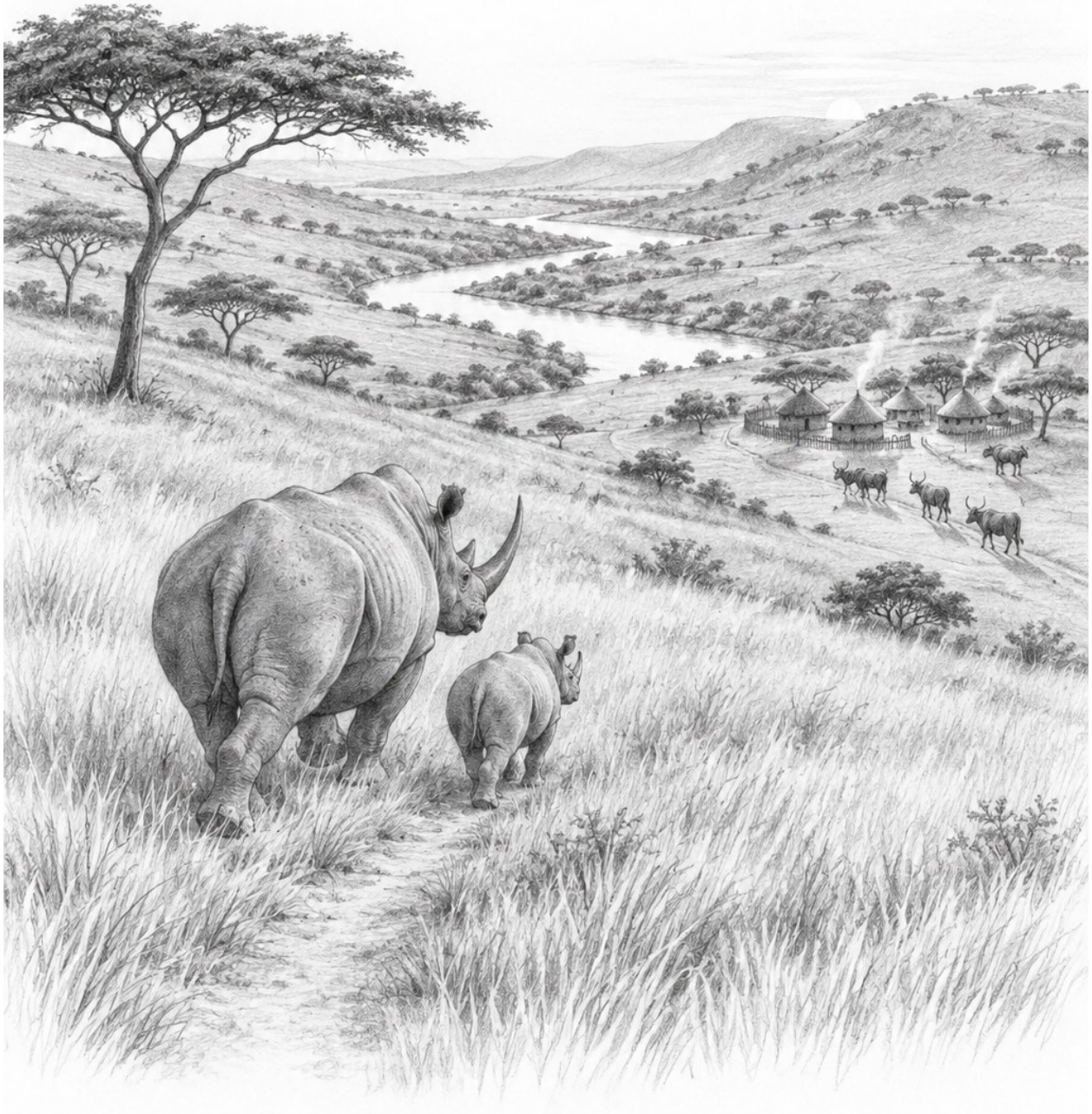

THE LAST REFUGE
MENDI TAUKWENA

The Last Refuge

Story by Mendi Taukwena



CHAPTER ONE

The Hills Before the Tears

Come, little ones. Come and sit where I can see you.

The sun is going down over Madikwe and the evening birds are calling, and that means it is time. Time for a story.

Tonight I will tell you about Bhejane. You know Bhejane, the great rhino who walks our plains so quietly you can look straight at him and not see him standing there. But Bhejane's story did not begin here in Madikwe. No, no. It begins far away, a long, long journey from this place, in the green hills of Zululand.

So we must go there first.

Long ago, before fences, before roads, before the noise of the wide world reached those hills, there was a land of rolling green, where two rivers ran like two ribbons - the White Umfolozi and the Black Umfolozi - until they met and became one river, the way two families meet and become one people.

The hills were alive.

The thorn trees stood wide and flat like umbrellas the earth had opened for its children. The grass grew so tall and sweet that a young rhino could hide his whole body in it and only his ears would show, twitching like two little flags.

And the rhinos! Oh, the rhinos of those hills. They were the great old ones of the land. They walked paths their grandmothers' grandmothers had walked, paths worn smooth into the red soil, from the river to the hills and back again. They knew every mud wallow, every salt lick, every shady tree where the ticks grew fat.

They shared that land with people, too.

In the valleys stood the homesteads, round huts in their round kraals, and the cattle coming home in the evening with their slow bells and their long shadows. Herdboys sang on the hillsides. Smoke rose from the cooking fires and hung blue in the evening air. This was the land of the Zulu people, the people of the sky, and their great king, and the people knew the rhinos the way you know the elders of your own village - you do not walk behind them too closely, you greet them with respect, and you leave them room to pass.

For many, many rains it was like this. The rhinos walked their old paths. The people kept their herds. The rivers ran. Children were born. Rhino calves were born too, tottering after their mothers on stiff little legs, and the hills held them all, the way a

grandmother holds the whole family in one house.

It was into this world that Bhejane's story truly begins - long before Bhejane himself, with his ancestors, the rhinos of those hills.

I cannot tell you all their names, little ones, for the hills keep some secrets to themselves. But I can tell you this: they were the children of Zululand. The red soil of those valleys was the first soil under their feet. The first sounds they ever heard were the river, the wind in the thorn trees, the cattle bells, and the songs of the people drifting up from the valley below.

They belonged to that land, and that land belonged to them, in the old way that has no papers and no fences - the way of kinship.

Their story is Bhejane's inheritance. And so it is his story too.

And for a long time, the world of the hills was whole.

But stories, like rivers, do not stand still. Somewhere beyond those hills, change was already walking, the way thunder walks behind the clouds long before the rain arrives.

That part of the story is hard, and I will tell it to you honestly, because you are strong enough to hear it.

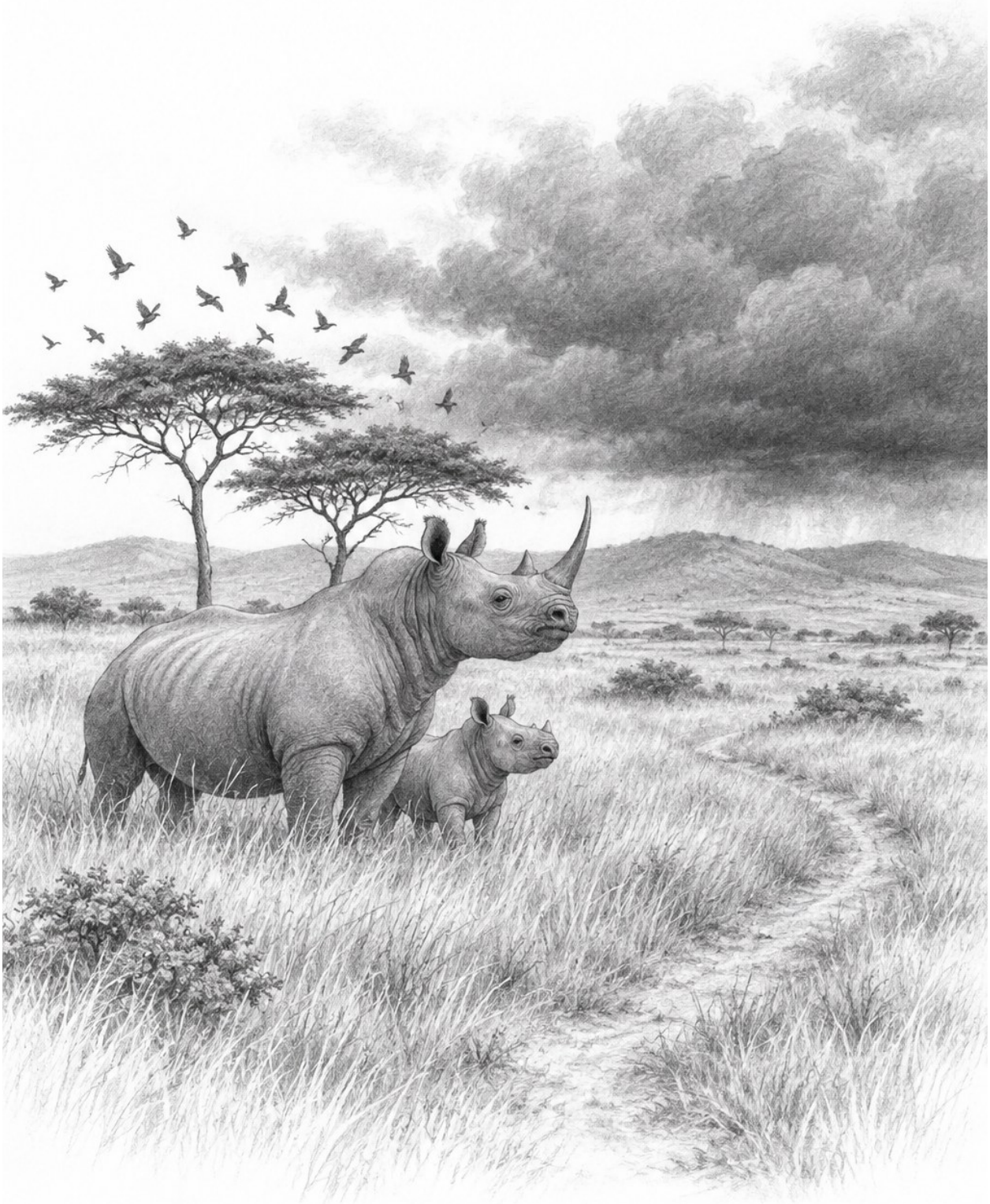
But not tonight.

Tonight, the hills are still green. The rivers are still running. The herdboys are still singing, and the rhinos are walking their old, old paths home in the evening light.

Hold that picture in your heart, little ones. Hold it close.

Because before you can understand what was lost, you must first know what was there.

Sleep well. Tomorrow, the story goes on.



CHAPTER TWO

When the Thunder Came

Come, little ones. Come close again.

The fire is warm tonight, here at Madikwe, and Bhejane is out there somewhere in the dark, walking slowly under the stars, as he does. Can you smell the evening? The dust settling, the dry grass, the rain still hiding behind the hills.

Hold that good smell. You will need it. For tonight, as I promised, the story grows heavy.

You remember the thunder I spoke of? The change that was walking behind the clouds?

It came slowly at first. It came as strangers.

Strangers on horseback, from far over the sea, carrying sticks that spoke with fire and thunder. The people of the hills called such a gun isibhamu, and when it spoke, the whole valley heard, and the birds rose from the trees like dark leaves.

The strangers did not come to greet the rhinos, as the people of the homesteads greeted them. They did not leave them room to pass. They came for the horns on their noses, and for the pride of saying they had conquered something great.

The rhinos had walked those hills since the time of their grandmothers' grandmothers. A grown rhino feared little and hurried for nobody.

So when the thunder-sticks spoke, the great ones stood and lifted their heads, wondering at the noise.

And some of them did not walk home that evening.

Little ones, I will not paint that picture too darkly for you. You are young, and the night is short. But I will not lie to you either. Rain after rain, fewer rhinos walked the old red paths. Fewer calves tottered after their mothers in the tall sweet grass. The mud wallows dried up with nobody to stir them, and the oxpeckers sat on bare branches, waiting for backs that did not come.

And the people of the hills were carrying their own sorrow in those years. War came to the kingdom of the Zulu, and it broke many things - homes, herds, and old ways. Even the house of the great king was brought low. The people who had shared the land with the rhinos for so long were now fighting for the land itself, and the old balance between the people and the rhinos was swept away in the same storm.

That is the truth of it, and it is a heavy truth: when the people suffered, the rhinos suffered too. The same storm beat down on them all.

The old paths grew over. Grass crept back across the trails that grandmothers' grandmothers had worn smooth. And the smell of the hills changed. The rain still fell on the red soil, but now it fell on empty paths, and the wind carried dust and smoke and something else - a silence where the slow rumbling greetings of rhinos used to be.

Year by year, the hills grew quieter.

Until at last, in all that wide green country, the rhinos were gone from almost everywhere. Gone from the valleys. Gone from the ridges. Gone from the riversides where they had drunk since before anyone's memory.

Almost everywhere, little ones.

Almost.

For in one hidden place, between the two rivers, the White Umfolozi and the Black Umfolozi, where the hills fold over each other like a mother folding her arms, a small few remained. A handful of the great old ones, walking softly in the long grass, keeping the last of the old paths open.

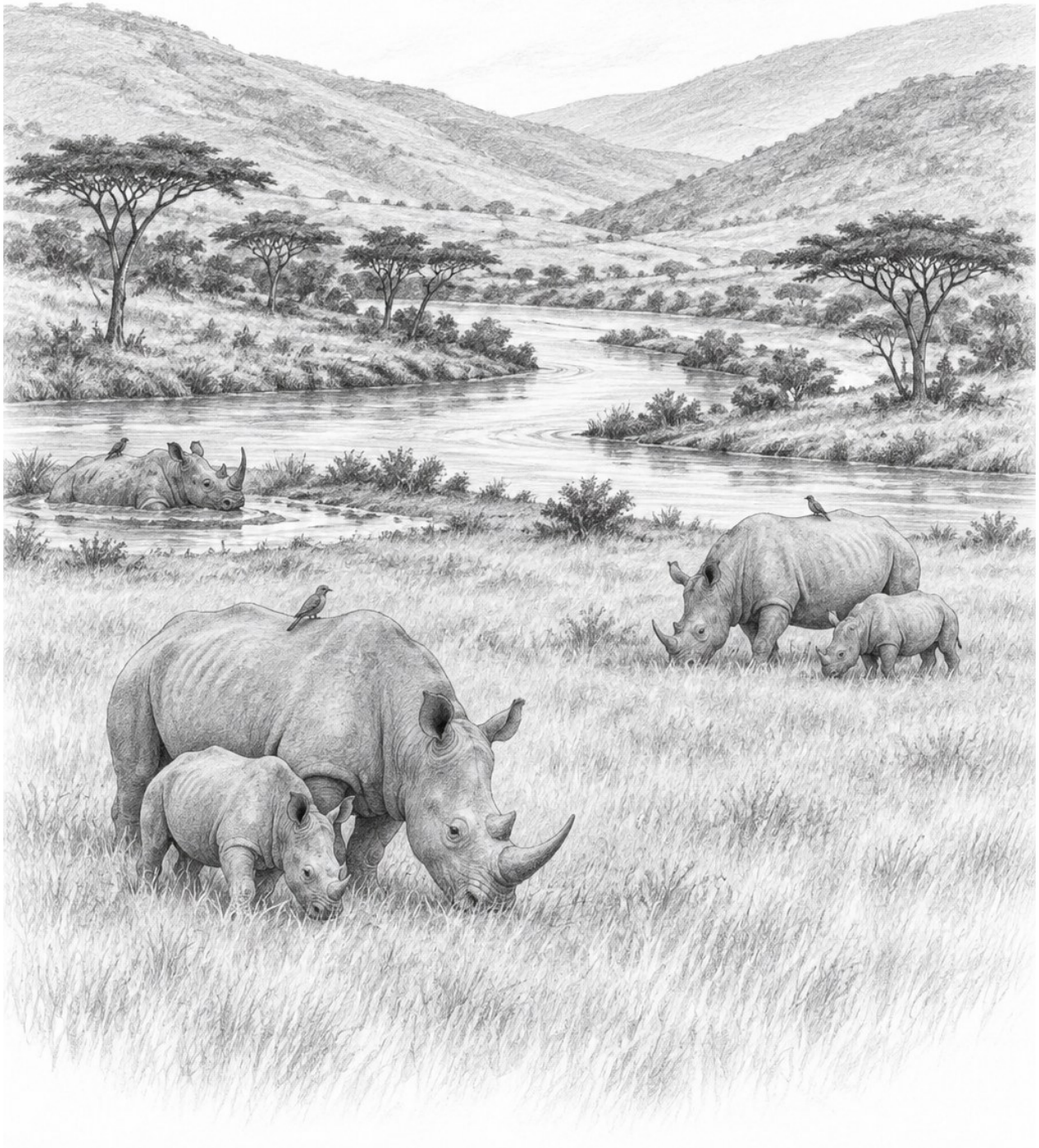
The very last of the hills' rhinos.

Their refuge.

Tomorrow I will tell you of that hidden place, and of the people who said: this far, no further. For the story does not end in silence, little ones. It does not.

But tonight, let the fire crackle, and let your heart be a little sore. It is good to feel the weight of what was nearly lost. That weight is how we learn to hold things gently.

Sleep now. The story goes on tomorrow.



CHAPTER THREE

This Far, No Further

Come, little ones. Come and sit.

Tonight the fire burns a little brighter, for tonight the story turns toward the light.

You remember where we left the rhinos - a small few, holding on between the White Umfolozi and the Black Umfolozi, where the hills fold over each other like a mother's arms. The very last of the hills' rhinos.

Let me tell you who these last ones were. They were the white rhinos of Umfolozi - and no, little ones, they were not white at all, but grey as river stones. White rhinos are the broad ones, the gentle grazers, with wide square mouths made for cropping grass, and long heads they carry low, the way humble giants walk. In those days, there were so few of them left that you could have counted them slowly, one by one, and finished before the fire burned down.

The thunder-sticks, and the ploughs and fences that followed them, had taken all the rest.

But now, at last, something new happened in those hills.

People looked at the emptying land and said: this far, no further.

A law was made in those days, and the law said the land between the two rivers was set aside for the wild ones. A reserve, they called it - Umfolozi. It was one of the very first places in all of Africa where the law itself stood guard over wild animals. Think of that, little ones. After all those years of thunder, the people's own law became a shield around the rhinos.

Watchers were appointed to walk the boundaries - game guards, they were called - and little by little, the thunder-sticks in the refuge grew quiet.

And the last ones breathed.

Slowly, slowly - for rhinos do everything slowly, except charge - the refuge began to fill with life again. A calf was born, and then another, tottering after their mothers on stiff little legs, as calves had done in those hills since before anyone's memory. The mud wallows were stirred again. The oxpeckers found warm backs to ride. And in the evenings, when the light turned the river gold, the slow rumbling greetings of rhinos could be heard once more, rolling across the valleys like a song the hills remembered.

Rain after rain, the few became more. The more became many. The little refuge between the rivers, the place where the white rhino had come to hide, became the place where the white rhino came back to life.

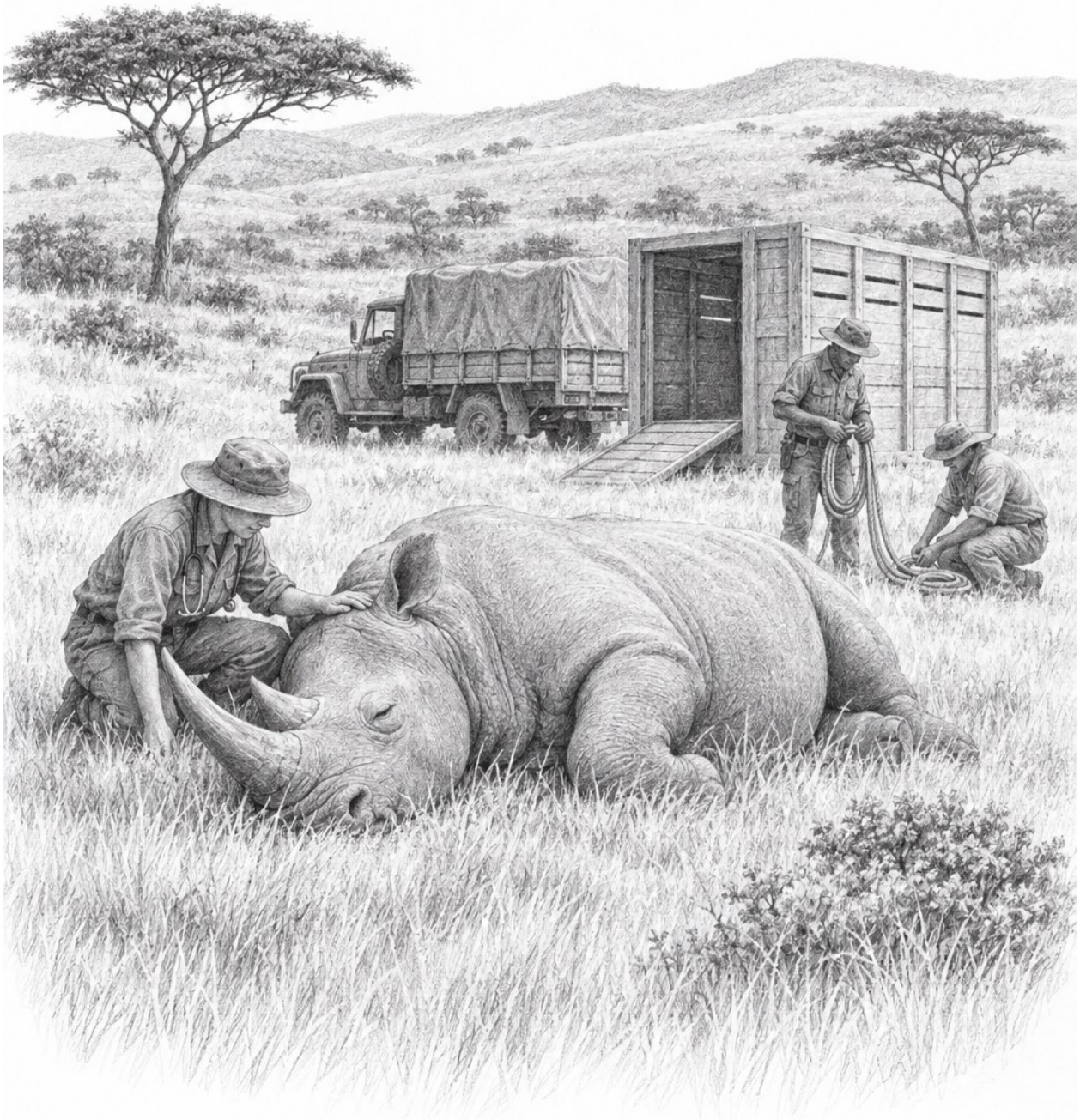
Umfolozi, little ones. The last refuge - and the first home of hope.

And here is the wonder I will leave you with tonight. The rhinos of Umfolozi grew so strong and so many that one day, people would carry the children of those hills out into the wide world, to bring other quiet places back to life. The refuge would begin to give back.

But that is tomorrow's story.

Tonight, let your heart be glad. The thunder came, and the thunder passed, and the great grey ones are still here.

Sleep well, little ones. Tomorrow, the story goes on.



CHAPTER FOUR

The Refuge Gives Back

Come, little ones. Come and sit by the fire.

Out there on the plains, Bhejane is grazing in the starlight, tearing the sweet grass with his wide mouth, slow and content. Watch him a moment. For tonight's story is about how a small hidden place between two rivers gave a gift to the whole wide land.

You remember how the refuge healed. Rain after rain, the few became many, and the white rhinos of Umfolozi grew strong again.

And then the people of the reserve faced a new question. A happy question, but a big one: what happens when the refuge grows full? When the hills that saved the rhino have given the rhino back its strength - where do all those rhinos go?

For the answer, the people of the refuge had to learn something brand-new to them: how to move a rhino.

Think of it, little ones! A rhino is not a goat you can lead on a rope. A rhino is two tons of muscle and stubbornness, with a horn in front and no patience behind. You cannot push him. You cannot pull him. You certainly cannot ask him nicely.

But the people of the refuge were patient, and they were clever. There was a warden there named Ian Player, and beside him his mentor, Magqubu Ntombela, the great tracker who knew the ways of the wild ones the way you know the path to your own front door. Together with their team, they found a way. A dart of sleep-medicine, carefully measured and given by skilled hands - animal doctors working beside the wardens - and the great grey one would grow drowsy and lie down to dream. Then came the ropes and the crate, with kind eyes watching every breath, and the lorry with its engine humming, and the long slow journey over the hills.

And when the crate opened, the rhino would step out into new country. New grass. New rivers. New hills that had not heard the rumbling greeting of a rhino in many, many years.

They called this work Operation Rhino.

Some of the children of Umfolozi went to a great reserve far to the north, called Kruger, where no white rhino had walked for a long time. Others went to other wild places across the land, and some even crossed the sea to parks far away. In many of those new homes, the same miracle happened. The newcomers found the grass

sweet. The wallows welcomed them. And soon there were calves again - little ears twitching, stiff little legs tottering - on hills that had almost forgotten what a rhino calf looks like.

The refuge was giving back.

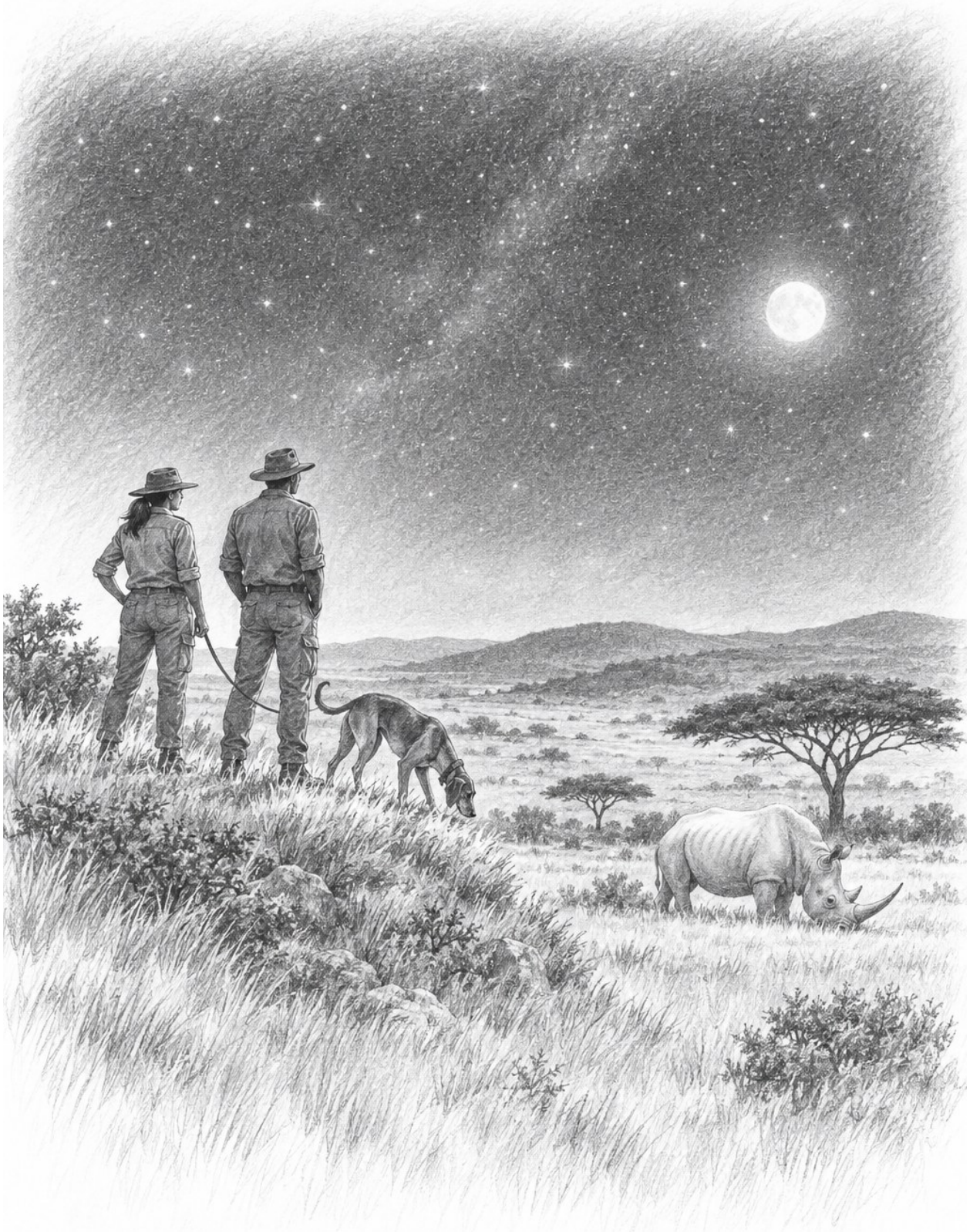
And it kept on giving. Rain after rain, year after year, the children and grandchildren and great-grandchildren of the last few walked out into the world. The little herd that you could once have counted before the fire burned down became hundreds, and the hundreds became thousands, and the thousands became many thousands, until the white rhino walked free again in places where people had only known it from their grandparents' stories.

That, little ones, is why tonight matters so much to me.

For when I watch Bhejane out there, grazing in the starlight, I see more than one rhino. I see the last few between the rivers, holding on. I see the wardens and the trackers and the crates on the lorries. Nearly every southern white rhino walking free today can trace its story back to that little refuge between the White Umfolozi and the Black Umfolozi. Their story is Bhejane's inheritance, just as it is the inheritance of every one of his kind.

The last refuge became the first home of hope - and hope, little ones, is a thing that multiplies when you share it.

Sleep well. The story goes on.



CHAPTER FIVE

The Second Storm

Come, little ones. Come and sit close tonight.

The fire is small and the stars are many, and Bhejane is grazing out there in the dark, as he does. I am glad he cannot hear tonight's story, for tonight I must tell you something that is not yet finished - something that is happening even now, while the fire crackles.

After Operation Rhino, for many years, the great grey ones knew peace. Year after year, far fewer rhinos were harmed than in the dark old days. The children of Umfolozi multiplied. The old hills sang their rumbling song, and new hills learned it too.

But greed, little ones, is a weed. You can pull it out, and think the garden is clean, and then one season its seeds blow back on the wind.

Far over the sea, people began to pay great sums of money for rhino horn. Horn! Which is made of keratin - the very same stuff as your own fingernails! But lies grew up around it like weeds too, and where there are lies and money, trouble follows.

In the year we call 2008, the second storm broke over the rhinos.

The thunder-sticks spoke again. Not for land this time, not for pride - for horn alone. Year after year the count of lost rhinos climbed, and at the worst of it, more than a thousand rhinos were taken in a single year in our country alone. Even the refuge between the rivers, the place that had saved the white rhino, was struck. Poachers - that is what we call those who take what is not theirs to take - poachers came in the night to the very hills that had sheltered the last few.

I will not pretend to you, little ones. Those were dark years, and some of them are still dark. It grieves me to tell it. You already know why it must be told.

But listen now. Listen to what the storm found when it returned.

It found the watchers waiting.

The rangers of the reserves walked out into the night to meet it - brave women and men who guard the wild ones while the rest of the world sleeps. Clever dogs learned to follow the poachers' scent through the bush. The animal doctors came with their skill, to save the hurt ones who could be saved. People from the communities near the reserves joined the watching too. And all across the country, people who loved the rhinos sat down together - rangers and chiefs, scientists and farmers, old people

and young - to talk and to plan how best to protect them. When people who care sit down together, little ones, that is not a small thing. That is how storms are turned.

And in some years, in some places, the count of the lost has fallen. The danger has not passed, and no one can promise the way ahead. But the fight is being fought, by people who have decided that the great grey ones will not vanish on their watch.

This far, no further. Do you hear how the old words live on?

And so tonight, when I look out at Bhejane grazing peacefully under our stars, I do not only see the past. I see the question the story is asking you.

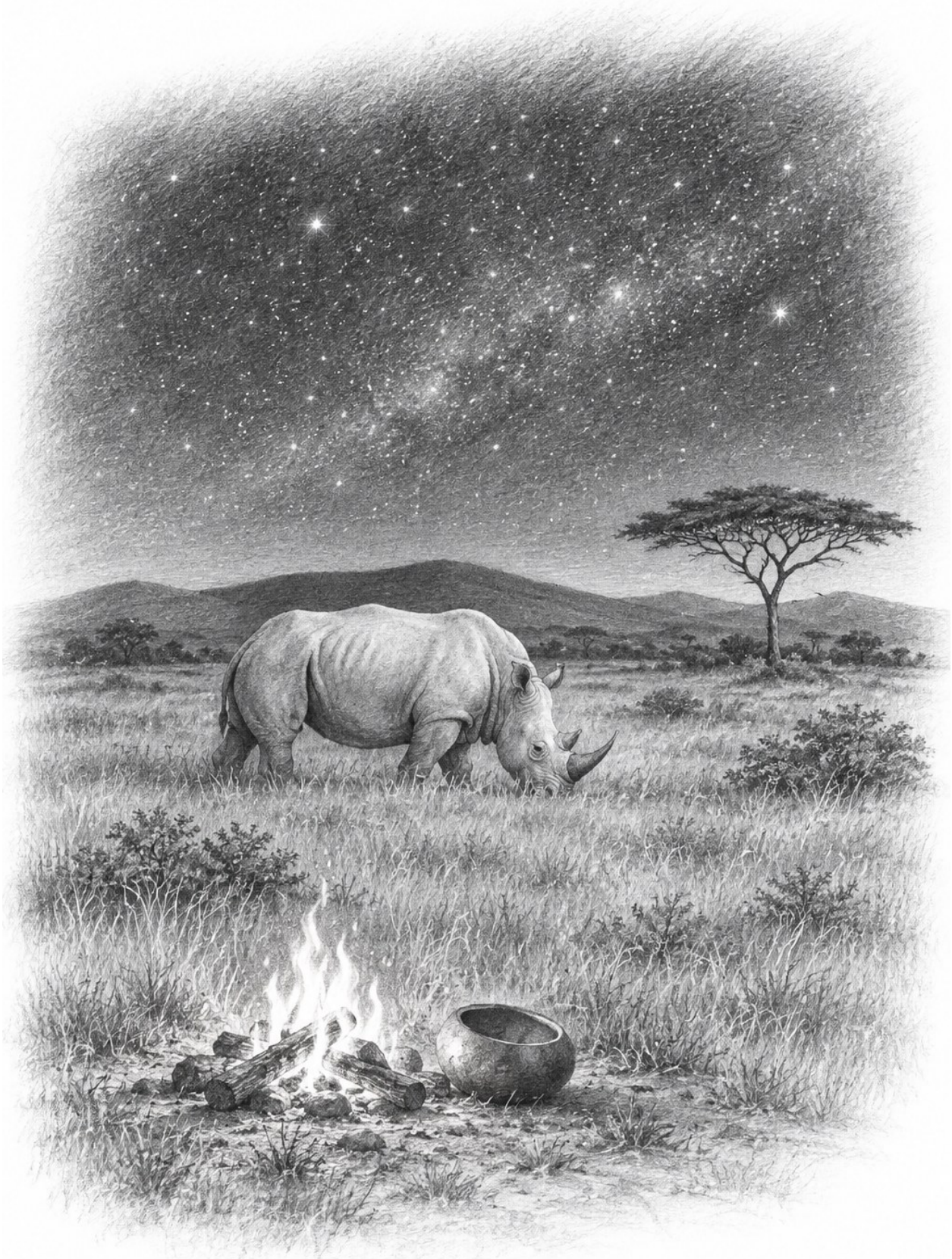
For this is the truth of stories, little ones: they do not really end. They are handed down, like a calabash from one set of hands to the next. The hills held the rhinos. The refuge held them. The wardens and the trackers and the watchers held them.

And now the calabash comes to your hands.

You are the generation that will decide what the next chapter says. Not with thunder-sticks - with learning, with caring, with voices that speak up for those who cannot speak for themselves.

Sleep well, little ones. And when you wake, remember: the refuge is still giving back.

Now it gives the story to you.



THE CLOSING

The Calabash

The fire settles low. The stars turn slowly over Madikwe.

Out there in the dark, a great grey shape moves through the grass - grazing, breathing, at home. Bhejane is here tonight. His safety is not promised. But he is here.

And now you know what it took to keep him here.

Hold that feeling, little ones. Let it stay with you after the last page closes. It is not a sad feeling, and it is not a finished feeling. It is the feeling of a story that is still being written - and is waiting for you.

Sleep well. And when you wake, there is something you can do.

Learn about one threatened animal - any one that calls to you. Tell its story to someone, the way I have told you Bhejane's story. And name one thing, just one, that you can do to help protect its home.

Small hands, little ones. But the calabash has always been passed hand to hand.

A TRIBUTE

This story honours the people who said: this far, no further.

The warden Ian Player and his mentor, the great tracker Magqubu Ntombela, and their Operation Rhino team - Nick Steele, John Clark, Owen Letley, Dr Toni Harthoorn, and many others of the Natal Parks Board - who learned how to carry rhinos to safety and gave the white rhino back its future.

The game guards and rangers who walked the boundaries then, and the rangers who walk them still, through the night, while the world sleeps.

The animal doctors whose skilled hands heal the hurt ones.

And the people of the communities around the reserves - neighbours of the rhino - whose watching and caring continues today.

Because of them, the great grey ones still walk the hills.

If we all keep watch, they always can.